

Jim Pham
Interview with an Expert
9/13/2006

In discussion with Johnson Aremu at Oracle Corporation, Johnson worked as a technology specialist in database technology. He had a strong understanding of computer-related technologies and the Internet. Johnson and I discussed the effective uses of technologies for communication. In addition, we also provided some insight into future technology. He firmly believed that technology continues to change the way people work and live. According to Johnson, today's technology is not limited to businesses; institutions are using it to improve work processes and communication. In addition, technology is not just for businesses and institutions; it is also available for residential use. He and I both think that Internet users are approaching a critical mass of technology usage. Furthermore, since the expansion of the Internet in 1991, the growth has been exponential. According to Morgan Stanley's Communication Equipment Research, the number of Internet users worldwide is approaching 2 billion. In fact, computers, laptops, cell phones, and other digital devices can be found just about everywhere. Increasingly, Internet users are accessing the Internet via broadband connections, and accessing the Web and its functionality is becoming the norm for business and residential users. It seems that no singular person is "out of touch" these days, and communication is always at our fingertips. Johnson and I are pretty much in agreement on all of these technological changes currently taking place across societies.

My question to Johnson was about the uses of the Internet and related communication technologies. My focus was on the most innovative uses of

communication technologies such as email, text messaging, online chat, WebBlog, cell phone, web conferencing, and the next generation of Web content (Web 2.0).

What are communications technologies that you are familiar with?

Like most Internet users, Johnson used email, blogs, Web conferencing, text messaging, instant messaging, online chat, cell phones, and other terrestrial communications. Johnson's primary methods of communication were cell phones and email, but he preferred face-to-face communication. He said that email, phone messages, and other technological communications were poor means of communication and were often cited as problems in organizations. However, he said that technologies such as cell phones and email are becoming increasingly common means of communication for most people. In addition, he said that Web conferencing, conference calls, email, chat rooms, or virtual meeting spaces are convenient tools.

What do you think about blogs, online chat, and instant messages?

He said that a blog is a good way to communicate your personal thoughts and opinions online, but people need to keep blog posts short and to the point. He thinks that online chat and instant messages are becoming much more widely used and have now become actual standards in their own right. Johnson used instant messages to communicate with his peers at the office and online chat to keep in touch with his family members and friends but he warned: messages can be stored indefinitely on the receiving computer.

How do you deal with email, instant messages, and spam?

Email and instant messages are generally not encrypted; therefore, they're vulnerable to spam and viruses that plague email. He said that spammers had also been able to send unsolicited spam messages to Blogs and even cell phone ringtones, photographs, wallpapers, and song lyrics. Johnson warned that any technology that travels across the Internet has to be carefully monitored. Users need to make sure that all incoming messages are from known sources and recognizable users. In addition, users may want to purchase anti-spam software and security-oriented software to protect them from spammers.

Is it all about the Internet?

Yes. It is all about the Internet. The Internet is more than just Web surfing and information retrieval; it is a centralized communications network. Users should not be surprised that the anonymous nature of Internet communication attracts a fair number of predators, spyware, and spammers.

Where is Technology Headed?

Not only do the Internet, Weblogs, online chat, instant messages, cell phones, and email provide new ways for people to connect, but communication technologies are also expanding very rapidly. There is a new movement of the Internet about Web 2.0, which is a new generation of web documents that have morphed into a web of data. With Web 2.0, users are no longer just looking at the same old sources for information; they are turning to tools to aggregate and remix microcontent in new and useful ways. The effects of Web 2.0 are far-reaching. Like all paradigm shifts, it affects the people who use it socially, culturally, and even politically

What are the available methods of communication to educators?

Educators are integrating technology tools such as video, presentation, multimedia, and the Internet into their teaching. In addition, they talk about practical issues such as teaching techniques, learning styles, assessment, and how technology helps them meet their curriculum goals.

I agree with Johnson that communications technology continues to shape businesses, colleges, and universities; therefore, it is important for future leaders in education to keep current with the latest technology

I also agree with Johnson that technology allows us to deliver dynamic presentations and training at the click of a mouse. We can collaborate with remote co-workers and volunteers online and prepare for face-to-face meetings with advance materials. We can review documents in real time. Communication technologies can save money if institutions eliminate printed brochures and direct people to their websites instead.

Finally, I believe that new technologies are transforming the way people work, and such technology applications help boost productivity.